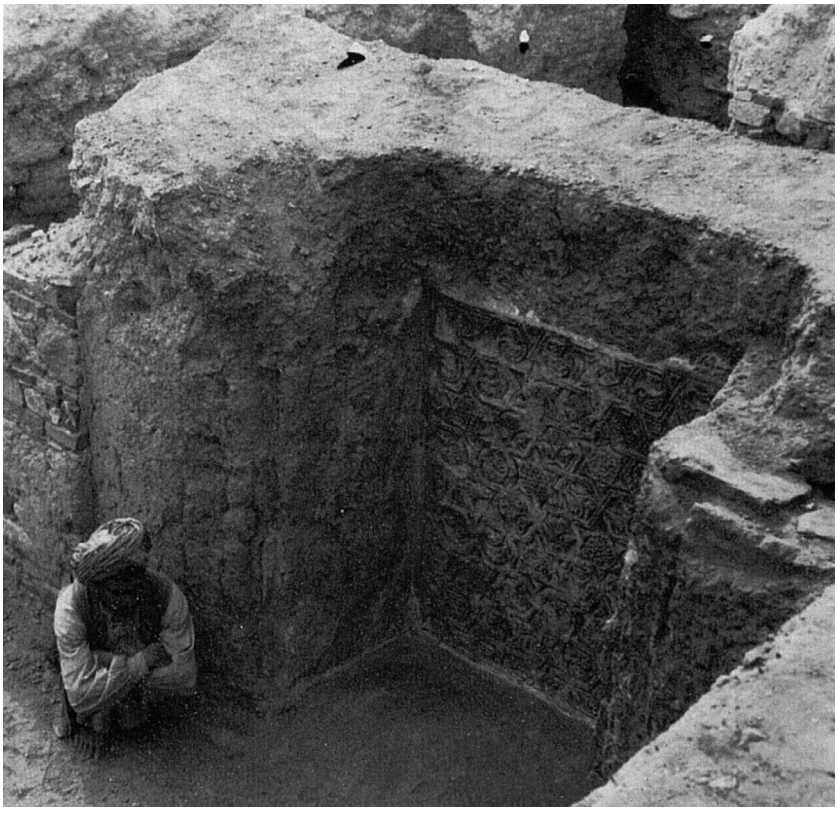


Figure 3.21 *Barfak II/"Danestama,"* mihrab *from southeast. From Le Berre 1970: pl. IIIc.*

palaces constructed and occupied throughout the eleventh–early twelfth centuries. The elevations of Ghulghula's building remains were also punctuated with blind arcades, not dissimilar to the large Southern Palace at Lashkari Bazar (see Chapter 5): in both cases, the walls most often showed a large, blind central arch flanked on each side by three smaller ones. Moreover, the traceable contours of historical walls highlighted a preference for cruciform configurations, that is, central courtyards with alcoves in the centers of the four sides (the four-*ivan* plan), creating intersecting perpendicular axes.[76] Such configurations were also in evidence at Lashkari Bazar and, most noticeably, at the royal palace of Ghazna, which was until recently attributed to the Ghaznavid sultan Mas'ud III (r. AH 492–508/ 1099–1115 CE), but is now thought to have had several prior phases of construction and occupation.[77]

In comparison with Sarkhushak's distinctively "hybrid" palatial architecture – combining Indic and Islamic-Persianate building forms and construction methods – Ghulghula's remains appear to be largely, if not exclusively, reminiscent of the Persianate palaces of Ghazna and Lashkari